



A FREE GUIDE

Start Your Own Second Brain

Stop losing your best ideas. Build an external memory that remembers everything for you — in about 30 minutes, for free.

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What a second brain actually is

A second brain is one place where everything you know, think, and learn gets written down — so your real brain can stop trying to remember it all.

Every idea you've ever had at 1 AM. Every video that changed how you think. Every plan you made and forgot by Friday. Right now those live in your camera roll, your notes app, six screenshots, and nowhere. They die there.

A second brain is the fix: a single folder of plain text notes on your computer that holds all of it. Your goals, your projects, your ideas, what you learned this week, what you decided and *why*. Searchable. Connected. Permanent.

Your brain is for *having* ideas — not for storing them.

WHAT IT IS NOT

- ◆ **Not a productivity aesthetic.** No 40-tab Notion dashboard you abandon in two weeks. Plain notes, used daily, beat pretty systems used never.
- ◆ **Not journaling.** A journal looks backward. A second brain works forward — you put things in so you can use them later.
- ◆ **Not an app you have to buy.** The whole thing runs on free software and files you own.

I'm a 16-year-old builder and I run my whole life on this — projects, money, goals, patterns I notice in myself. This guide is the exact starting version of my system, cut down to what matters on day one.

The forgetting problem

You don't have an idea problem. You have a memory problem.

Within 24 hours you forget most of what you learned today. That's not a flaw in you — it's how human memory works. The people who seem "smart" or "always on it" aren't remembering more. They're **storing** more, outside their head.

WHAT CHANGES WHEN YOU HAVE ONE

- ◆ **Ideas compound instead of evaporating.** A thought from March connects to a thought from June and becomes a plan. That can't happen if March is gone.
- ◆ **You stop re-deciding things.** Decided something hard last month? It's written down, with the reasoning. You never have the same argument with yourself twice.
- ◆ **You see your own patterns.** When your thoughts are in one place, you start noticing what you keep coming back to, where you keep getting stuck, what actually works for you. That self-knowledge is worth more than any course.
- ◆ **Everything you make gets easier.** Content, school, projects, business — they all draw from the same pool of captured material instead of starting from a blank page.

THE HONEST PITCH

The second brain isn't extra work on top of your life. It's the same thinking you already do — captured, instead of lost. The work happens either way. The only question is whether you keep the output.

The 30-minute setup

1 Download Obsidian — free

obsidian.md — Mac, Windows, phone. It's a notes app that stores everything as plain text files *on your device*. You own the files forever. No subscription, no lock-in.

2 Create a vault

Obsidian calls your notes folder a "vault." Name it whatever you want — Second Brain works fine. This one folder is the whole system.

3 Make exactly five folders

Not twenty. Five. This is the structure I'd start with today:

Second Brain/

— Inbox/	← everything lands here first. no sorting at capture time
— Projects/	← one note per active thing you're building or doing
— Knowledge/	← things you learn — one note per topic
— Journal/	← timeline. decisions, events, what happened
— Me/	← goals, values, patterns you notice in yourself

4 Write your first three notes

In Projects/: one note per thing you're actively working on — even if it's just "get my grades up." In Me/: a note called Goals — what you actually want, dated. In Journal/: today's date, three sentences on where you are right now. Done. It's alive.

THE ONE FEATURE THAT MATTERS

In Obsidian, type `[]` inside any note to link to another note. Link your project note to your goals note. Links are what turn a pile of notes into a brain — connected thoughts you can walk through later.

Capture everything. Sort almost nothing.

The system runs on one habit: when something worth keeping crosses your mind, it goes in the Inbox. Ten seconds. No formatting. No perfect title.

WHAT COUNTS AS "WORTH KEEPING"

- ◆ An idea — for a project, a video, a business, anything
- ◆ Something you learned that made you stop and think
- ◆ A decision you made and the reason you made it
- ◆ A problem you're stuck on, written out honestly
- ◆ Something someone said that you don't want to lose

MAKE CAPTURE STUPID-EASY

Friction kills this habit. Put Obsidian on your phone home screen. Or use voice notes and transcribe later. Or text things to yourself and move them at night. The rule isn't *how* — the rule is **same place, every time**.

If it's not written down, it didn't happen — your future self has no other way to know.

Don't organize while capturing. The moment capturing requires decisions ("which folder? what tags?"), you'll stop doing it. Dump it in Inbox and move on with your day. Sorting is a separate job, and it's the next page.

The 15-minute weekly loop

Once a week — pick a day, keep it — you process the Inbox. This is the whole maintenance cost of the system. Fifteen minutes.

1 Empty the Inbox

Each captured note either moves to its folder (Projects / Knowledge / Journal / Me), gets merged into a note that already exists, or gets deleted. Deleting is allowed. Half of what you capture won't matter a week later — that's normal and fine.

2 Link while you sort

Every note you file should link to at least one other note with `[[ ]]`. New idea about a project? Link the project. Lesson learned? Link it to the goal it serves. This is how the brain gets smarter over time.

3 Read your Projects folder

Just read it. You'll instantly see what moved this week and what's been sitting untouched. That ten-second glance is more honest than any to-do app — it shows you what you actually do, not what you planned.

WHY WEEKLY WORKS WHEN DAILY FAILS

Daily systems collapse the first busy week — I know because mine did. A weekly loop survives bad weeks. Miss one? You do it next week and the system is fine. Build the floor you'll actually hit, not the ceiling that looks good.

Add AI on top

(this is where it gets unfair)

A folder of notes is a memory. A folder of notes plus AI is a second brain that **talks back**.

Because your vault is plain text, AI can read it. That changes what it is. You stop asking a chatbot generic questions and start asking *your own life* questions — and getting answers grounded in everything you've written.

LEVEL 1 — COPY & PASTE (FREE, START TODAY)

Open ChatGPT or Claude, paste in your goals note and a project note, and ask: "*Based on this, what should I focus on this week?*" or "*What am I avoiding here?*" The answers get sharp fast, because for once the AI has real context — yours.

LEVEL 2 — AI THAT READS THE VAULT ITSELF

Tools like Claude Code can open your vault folder directly — read any note, write new ones, connect things you forgot were related. Mine runs the whole system: it processes new captures, updates project notes, spots patterns in my behavior, and remembers every decision I've made and why.

WHAT THAT ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

I can ask "what did I decide about this in May?" and get the answer with receipts. I get called out when I'm repeating a mistake I've documented before — by an AI quoting *my own notes* back at me. It's the closest thing to a copy of yourself that works while you sleep.

Start at Level 1. Seriously — paste-and-ask is 80% of the value at 0% of the setup. Level 2 is where I live, and it's where this is all going; I show that build on my page.

The five ways people kill their second brain

1 Building instead of using

A week of folder design, zero notes captured. The system isn't the folders — it's the habit. Five folders, start capturing, adjust later. Done beats perfect.

2 Over-organizing

Tags, sub-folders, color systems, templates for the templates. Every layer of structure is friction, and friction kills capture. Search and links do the organizing in this system. Stay flat.

3 App-hopping

Notion this month, Obsidian next month, some new tool from a TikTok after that. Every move resets the habit to zero. The tool was never the problem. Pick one, stay a year.

4 Capturing other people's stuff only

A vault full of podcast quotes and saved threads is a scrapbook, not a brain. The high-value notes are *yours* — your ideas, your decisions, your reasons. Capture what you think, not just what you consume.

5 Writing for an audience

Nobody reads this but you (and your AI). Write ugly, write honest, write fast. The note that says what you were actually afraid of is worth fifty polished ones.

The best system is the one still running in six months.

Your first 30 minutes, start to finish

- ◆ **Minute 0–5:** download Obsidian, create your vault
- ◆ **Minute 5–10:** make the five folders — Inbox, Projects, Knowledge, Journal, Me
- ◆ **Minute 10–25:** write the first three notes — your goals, one project, today's journal entry
- ◆ **Minute 25–30:** link them together with `[[ ]]` and put Obsidian on your phone home screen

Then live your life and capture as you go. Sunday, run the 15-minute loop. That's the entire system. In a month you'll have a brain outside your head. In a year you'll wonder how you operated without one.



I'm building my whole life on this system — in public.

The AI agents, the projects, the money, the mistakes — all of it gets documented. Follow along, and join the weekly letter where I share what I'm learning as I go.

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